

UNMARKED

BOOK 1 OF TIME JUMPERS



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Chapter 3: The Broken Watch

The afternoon sun slanted through the dusty windows of Yasin's clock shop, casting long shadows across the workbenches. The steady tick-tock of dozens of timepieces filled the air, a soothing rhythm that usually calmed Yasin's mind. But today, as he carefully adjusted the delicate gears of the antique pocket watch, he felt a strange unease, as if the very fabric of time was slightly out of alignment.

The shop bell jangled violently, shattering the peace. Yasin looked up, startled, to see a young wide-eyed woman burst through the door. Her breath came in short gasps.

"Are you the clockmaker?" she demanded, her voice tight with barely contained emotion. "The one who can fix anything?"

Yasin set down his tools carefully, and studied the woman. She was perhaps in her late twenties, dressed in the smart attire of a professional complete with matching hijab, but rumpled and disheveled, as if she'd been running.

"I am Yasin Al-Razi," he said calmly, rising from his workbench. "How may I help you?"

The woman approached, fumbling in her bag. "My father's watch," she said, her voice cracking slightly. "It's... it's all I have left of him. Can you fix it?"

She produced an ornate pocket watch, cradling it in her palm as if it were made of spun glass. Yasin gestured for her to place it on the counter between them.

"May I?" he asked gently. At her nod, he picked up the watch, turning it over in his hands. It was a beautiful piece, intricately engraved, but clearly not functioning. As he examined it, the woman spoke again, her words tumbling out in a rush.

"I'm Layla. Layla Qadri. My father was a civil engineer. He... he used his first jump to prevent a building collapse. Saved dozens of lives." Her voice swelled with pride, then faltered. "His second jump was to say goodbye to my mother. She was dying, and he was trapped in another city during a disaster. He couldn't get to her in time, but... at least he got to say goodbye."

Yasin nodded, encouraging her to continue as he pried open the back of the watch. Inside, he found something unexpected: a modification, a counter of some kind, unlike anything he'd seen before.

Layla's voice dropped to almost a whisper. "His third jump... he used it last year. He wouldn't tell me why. Three weeks later, he died suddenly." She paused, her fingers gripping the edge of the workbench. "The doctors said it was an aneurysm. A weakness in a blood vessel that could have ruptured at any time—sitting at dinner, playing with grandchildren someday. They were very clear it had nothing to do with the jump itself."

"But?" Yasin prompted gently, hearing the unspoken weight in her words.

"But I've wondered," Layla said, her voice barely audible, "if the burden of what he saw... if carrying that knowledge for three weeks, trying frantically to document everything, not knowing if anyone would find it or believe it... I've wondered if that stress, that weight..." She couldn't finish.

Yasin set down his tools, giving her his full attention. "Knowledge can be a burden," he said softly. "The jumps don't harm us physically—that much we know. But what we see, what we learn, what we carry back with us—that can exact its own toll."

"Did the jump kill my father?" Layla asked bluntly, meeting his eyes.

Yasin chose his words carefully. "The aneurysm killed your father. The doctors confirmed that. But did the emotional weight of what he knew contribute to his stress, possibly to the conditions that led to the rupture? Only God knows for certain." He paused. "What I do know is that your

father chose to bear that burden so that others might be spared. He used his final jump not for personal gain, but to try to save thousands of lives. That's courage, even if—especially if—it came at a cost."

Layla nodded slowly, tears slipping down her cheeks. "The watch... it stopped at the exact moment of his third jump. As if time itself marked that choice."

"Perhaps it did," Yasin said. "A reminder that every jump, every choice, carries weight. Your father understood that. And he chose to carry it anyway."

Yasin looked up from the watch, meeting Layla's eyes. For the first time, he noticed the dark rings on her hands – two of them. She had already used two of her own jumps. The weight of that knowledge hung in the air between them.

"I think he jumped forward," Layla continued, her voice shaking. "Forty years—the dam's projected lifespan under optimal conditions. Maybe he saw the valley already destroyed, but couldn't tell when it had happened. Maybe he saw the aftermath of failure and spent his last three weeks documenting everything that could cause it to fail early."

She leaned forward, her eyes burning with intensity. "I have one jump left," she said, her voice barely above a whisper. "One chance to understand what he saw. Can you fix the watch by tomorrow?"

Yasin felt the weight of her desperation, saw the familiar look he'd witnessed in so many who used their jumps and lived with the consequences. He thought of his own unmarked hands, of the choice he made every day not to jump.

"I will try," he said softly, turning the watch over in his hands once more. "But Layla... sometimes the answer we seek isn't the one we need."

Layla's shoulders sagged, relief and frustration warring on her face. "I know," she said. "But I have to try. I have to know."

As Yasin carefully set the watch aside, preparing to begin work, he felt the familiar tug of temptation. To jump, to see, to know. But as always, he resisted. In the ticking of the clocks around him, in Layla's desperate eyes, in the weight of her father's mysterious last jump, he sensed the beginning of something larger than himself. A story of time, of choice, and of the courage it takes to live with uncertainty.

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